

THE GREAT RESCUE

*The Answers to
Pertinent Questions*

ALEX M. KURUVILLA

This page is intentionally left blank

THE GREAT RESCUE

The Answers to Pertinent Questions

THE GREAT RESCUE

The Answers to Pertinent Questions

Author: Alex M Kuruvilla

Copyright © 2024 by Alex M Kuruvilla

First Edition: November 2024

Published by:

The Word of Life Ministries

Musariath House (MRRRA 28A)

Janatha Lane Road, Vazhakkala

Kakkanad (West) – Kochi – 682 030

Kerala – INDIA

Mobile: +91 9633280848

Email: alexm.kuruvilla@gmail.com

eBook produced by

refinería®

THE GREAT RESCUE

The Answers to Pertinent Questions

ALEX M. KURUVILLA

THE WORD OF LIFE MINISTRIES
ERNAKULAM

This page is intentionally left blank

I am not feeling guilty of sin; am I guilty of sin?

In our legal system, when a judge finds a suspect violating the nation's laws, the suspect will be declared 'guilty of that crime'. The suspect's feeling of guilt is irrelevant here. He may have a feeling of guilt, or he may not have. The judge's verdict is irrespective of the suspect's feelings and sense. It is based on the evidence of violation. So is the case with sin.

In the matter of sin, most people are confused between the guilt of sin and the feeling of guilt. People think that because they do not feel guilty of their sins, they are not guilty of sin. We, the world's people, are accountable to a morally perfect and upright God for our evil desires, words, and deeds. The Bible says that *all* have been found guilty of sin by God Almighty, the omniscient supreme judge of this universe. Not only has He found us guilty of sin, but He has also

issued a verdict of death sentence on all. We are in a condemned state just like a condemned criminal who is kept in remand for the execution of the death sentence. That is our status quo. That is the plain truth. Unless God Almighty acquits you of your guilt of sin before mortal death you will have to suffer eternal death. Incidentally, eternal death is the worst form of existence beyond mortal death where sinners will be tormented eternally in hell where their worm does not die, and the fire is not quenched. There everyone will be salted with fire.

But we do not have to despair. We have a solid hope. Your attention is drawn to the following Bible verse: *'Everyone has sinned and fallen short of God's glorious standard, and all need to be made right with God by his grace, which is a free gift. They need to be made free from sin through Jesus Christ.'* [Romans 3:23-24 – NCV].

What is sin?

What then is sin? The sacred scripture, the Bible, defines sin as moral lawlessness – meaning violation of God's moral laws by the heart's intent and its expression through thoughts, words, and deeds. We read: *'Everyone who makes a practice of sinning also practices lawlessness; sin is lawlessness.'* [1 John 3:4 ESV].

Another translation: *'Everyone who sins is breaking God's law, for all sin is contrary to the law of God.'* [1 John 3:4 NLT]. In short, sin is the violation of God's moral laws, the Ten Commandments, either by the intent of the heart, deeds, or both. That leads us to the next question. [God's moral laws are given at the end of this booklet]

Which are God's moral laws?

The term 'law' referred to in the above verse (1 John 3:4) is the moral laws of God embodied in the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20: 2-17 & Deuteronomy 5:6-21). The Ten Commandments were engraved on two tablets of stones and given to the Jews through Moses. But the same Commandments are also engraved in the heart (i.e. the inner conscience) of everyone irrespective of caste, creed, race, color, or nationality. We read: *'Even Gentiles (i.e. non-Jews), who do not have God's written law, show that they know his law when they instinctively obey it, even without having heard it. They demonstrate that God's law is written in their hearts, for their own conscience and thoughts either accuse them or tell them they are doing right.'* [Romans 2:14-15 NLT].

Am I required to obey God?

Yes, for three reasons: (1) God is One and beside Him there is none; He is the absolute Sovereign God of all flesh; He is your Creator, (2) He created you in His image and likeness, subjecting you to His laws and purposes, (3) You are accountable to Him for your evil thoughts (or evil desires), words, and deeds. Therefore, by default, you must obey God's moral laws, the Ten Commandments.

Am I a sinner?

Not just you, but everyone born of humanity is a sinner by default. The sacred scripture says, *"Therefore, just as sin came into the world through one man, and death through sin, and so death spread to all men because all sinned."* [Romans 5:12]. We are part and parcel of the fallen human race. In Psalms 51 King David confesses: *"Behold, I was brought forth in iniquity, and in sin did my mother conceive me."* [Psalm 51:5]. We are born with a congenital heart condition called 'the sinful nature' (or wicked heart) that always seeks to oppose God [Jeremiah 17: 9-10]. We inherited this nature from Satan via the first man Adam. Incidentally, the word 'Satan' means the opposing one (or the adversary).

He is the source and personification of evil. He opposes God, who is the source and the personification of good. As Satan does, we continually rebel against God by violating His moral laws. We are violating His moral laws by either the intent of the heart or the actual deed or both. Thus, we oppose God. If you listen to your inner being, you can discern your sinful nature concerning God's moral laws.

Can't there be at least one person in humanity without sin?

No; there is none. The sacred Scripture confirms this truth. We read: *"Well then, should we conclude that we Jews are better than others? No, not at all, for we have already shown that **all people, whether Jews or Gentiles (i.e., non-Jews), are under the power of sin.** As the Scriptures say, **'No one is righteous— not even one.** No one is truly wise; no one is seeking God. All have turned away; all have become useless. No one does good, not a single one."* *"Their talk is foul, like the stench from an open grave. Their tongues are filled with lies."* *"Snake venom drips from their lips."* *"Their mouths are full of cursing and bitterness."* *"They rush to commit murder. Destruction and misery always follow them. They don't know where to find peace."* *"They have no fear of God at all."* Obviously, the law applies to those to whom it was given, for its purpose is to keep

people from having excuses and to show that *the entire world is guilty before God*. For no one can ever be made right with God by doing what the law commands. The law simply shows us how sinful we are.' [Romans 3:9-20 NLT]. The term, 'the law' is a direct reference to the Ten Commandments.

How does God save sinners?

Apostle Paul wrote to the Christians in Rome saying, *'For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek (i.e. the non-Jew). For in it the righteousness of God is revealed from faith for faith, as it is written, "The righteous shall live by faith."* [Romans 1:16-17 ESV].

The Bible says that the gospel (i.e., the message of Jesus Christ, the Rescuer) is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes. It means that the power of God to save sinners from their eternal death lies in the gospel of Jesus Christ. Apart from the gospel, there are no other means, repeat no other means, by which God can rescue a sinner. There are four keywords in the above verses: (1) The gospel, (2) Salvation, (3) Belief (or Faith), and (4) The righteousness of God. What do these terms mean?

What is the gospel?

The Gospel is the message of Jesus Christ and what He has accomplished for us (sinners) by His death on the cross, burial, and resurrection. The message is the good news to the sinner because if it should be positively responded to, it will make him/her leap and dance with joy. Why should it make one so joyful? Because the Holy God will acquit the sinner from his/her guilt of sin, He will declare him/her righteous. Thus, the sinner will be saved from eternal death.

Furthermore, this salvation which comes as the result of justification is a free gift from God. The salvation thus obtained secures you an unimaginable, indescribable quality of existence called 'eternal life'. We read: *"For the wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord."* [Romans 6:23 - ESV]. The quoted scripture emphatically says that salvation is given as a free gift of God. Therefore, salvation cannot be earned **by** your meritorious 'karma' (or good deeds). However, your good deeds ('good' according to God's standards) will secure you eschatological rewards once you are rescued from your sins. The seeming good deeds of an unsaved sinner will not be of any benefit to him,

because he must first undergo the wrath of God against his guilt of sin.

The gospel message of Jesus Christ is a double-edged sword. He who believes will be saved, but whoever does not believe will be condemned.

The risen Lord Jesus Christ while commissioning His disciples commanded them, *'And he said to them, "Go into all the world and proclaim the gospel to the whole creation. Whoever believes and is baptized will be saved, but whoever does not believe will be condemned.'* [Mark 16:15-16 - ESV]

Salvation from what?

Salvation is from the wrath of God that is to come. God is righteous. He is pure justice. He is the supreme judge of this universe. Therefore, He cannot leave the guilty unpunished. A day has been appointed to judge the living and the dead. On that day God would pour out His wrath on the guilty. That day is the day of God's vengeance against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men. That day is called the 'Day of the LORD' or the 'Day of the Son of Man'.

The Bible gives a graphic account of God's wrath on His great day as follows: *'When he opened the sixth seal, I looked, and behold, there was a great earthquake, and the sun became black as sackcloth,*

the full moon became like blood, and the stars of the sky fell to the earth as the fig tree sheds its winter fruit when shaken by a gale. The sky vanished like a scroll that is being rolled up, and every mountain and island was removed from its place. Then the kings of the earth and the great ones and the generals and the rich and the powerful, and everyone, slave and free, hid themselves in the caves and among the rocks of the mountains, calling to the mountains and rocks, "Fall on us and hide us from the face of him who is seated on the throne, and from the wrath of the Lamb (i.e., Jesus), for the great day of their wrath has come, and who can stand?" [Revelation 6:12-17].

You might say: "Okay, I agree that I am a sinner. But how does that matter to me?"

From the time of your conception in the womb of your mother, you inherit a sinful nature. And you live sinning against God and your neighbor (i.e., your fellow beings) continually. Therefore, God the Supreme Judge of this universe has found you guilty of sin, i.e., guilty of violating God's moral laws. And the Holy God has issued a verdict of punishment due to that guilt, which is eternal death. Incidentally, the term 'death' means separation; it does not mean annihilation. 'Eternal death' means eternal separation from

God, your Creator. So, in 'eternal death' one continues to exist but is eternally separated from God. That situation is unbearable and agonizing for the immortal human soul. It is like being in the eternal hellfire and not being consumed by it. The evidence of our condemned status is in the progressive decaying of our bodies and the inevitable mortal death that we all will face.

Mortal death is merely an announcement of the eternal death that is pronounced on each one of us. Mortal death is a reminder. It reminds us of the eternal death from which we will have no escape unless we get right with God before that happens. So, you and I are 'walking dead'. That truly is our status. The sacred Scripture confirms this truth. We read: *'Therefore, just as through one man sin entered the world, and death through sin, and thus death spread to all men because all sinned* – '[Romans 5:12 – NKJV]. Another translation: *'When Adam sinned, sin entered the world. Adam's sin brought death, so death spread to everyone, for everyone sinned.'* [Romans 5:12 – NLT]

Can I obey the Ten Commandments and get right with God?

Theoretically, it should be possible; but practically it is impossible. Why impossible? Because of the 'weakness of the flesh' (i.e. the

inherited sinful nature). How? The spirit of and the requirement behind God's moral laws (The Ten Commandments) is the same: selfless love. Only by loving God and loving man (24 x7) selflessly can we obey God's moral laws. Jesus Christ the incarnate Son of God confirms this truth. We read: *'Then one of them, a lawyer, asked Him (Jesus) a question, testing Him, and saying, "Teacher, which is the great commandment in the law?" Jesus said to him, "'You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your mind.' This is the first and greatest commandment. And the second is like it: 'You shall love your neighbor as yourself.' On these two commandments hang all the Law and the Prophets.'*" [Matthew 22:35-40 - NKJV]. When you break one of the Commandments, that violation equates to a violation of the entire Commandments. How? Because the violation takes place in the spirit of the commandment, which is love. And the tenth Commandment is 'You shall not covet', which deals with the intent of the heart. It means you shall not covet (desire) to break the other nine Commandments. Incidentally, the desire to violate any one of the first nine Commandments is classified as 'evil desire' or simply 'covetousness' by Jesus Christ, our Lord. Jesus said: *"What comes out of a person is what defiles him. For from within, out of the heart*

of man, come evil thoughts, sexual immorality, theft, murder, adultery, coveting, wickedness, deceit, sensuality, envy, slander, pride, foolishness. All these evil things come from within, and they defile a person." [Mark 7:20-23 - ESV]. **And we violate the tenth Commandment moment by moment with the intent of our hearts. Therefore, we cannot appease God by satisfying the law's requirement, selfless love.** We read: *"For no one can ever be made right with God by doing what the law commands. The law simply shows us how sinful we are."* [Romans 3:20 - ESV]. The Ten Commandments are not given as a means of salvation. They are compared to a mirror; they function as reflectors, reflecting the evil condition of the human heart.

What is the righteousness of God?

The God revealed in and through the Bible is morally perfect, meaning He is upright and virtuous. He is the embodiment of all goodness, perfectness, and pure justice. He is the source and the personification of the virtue, 'Good'. 'Good' is a title that belongs only to God. Hence, Jesus said: *"Why do you call me good? No one is good except God alone."* [Mark 10:18 - ESV]; 'And Jesus said to him, *"Why do you call me good? No one is good except God alone."* [Luke 18:19].

There is no darkness in God. In short, God is holy. The Bible says, *'The Lord is righteous in all his ways and kind in all his works.'* [Psalm 145:17]. Again, we read: *"The Rock, his work is perfect, for all his ways are justice. A God of faithfulness and without iniquity, just and upright is he."* [Deuteronomy 32:4]. And He is our Creator. He demands moral perfectness from man, the crown and roof of His creation. His command is: *"You shall be holy, for I the LORD your God am holy"* (Leviticus 19:2; 1 Peter 1:16). **God gave man the Ten Commandments, the moral laws, for him to know His standard of holiness or perfectness with which He would judge man.** But man failed God and failed continually due to his sinful nature, the wicked heart.

What is justification?

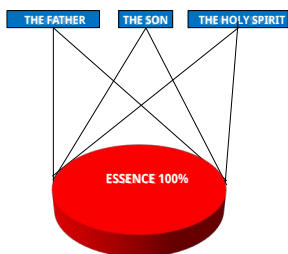
God the judge of all found you and me guilty of violating His moral laws. We are morally imperfect according to God's standard. If you were to escape God's execution of the death sentence pronounced on you, He should first remove your guilt of sin. And He cannot sweep your sins under the carpet. He must deal with sin by punishing sin thus satisfying His righteous character. Unless the Supreme Judge of this universe removes your guilt of sin, you will have

to suffer the death penalty on the Day of Judgment. **The act of removing the guilt of sin from a sinner is called justification.** God's process of removing the guilt of sin is done by (1) first punishing the sinner's guilt (see note below) which is followed by (2) clothing the sinner with God's own righteousness. **The acquitted sinner thus becomes the bearer of the righteousness of God.** The result of justification is salvation from the wrath of God to come.

What is the doctrine of the Holy Trinity?

The God revealed in and through the sacred Scripture is a triune being. God is One Being (i.e. one essence or one substance) eternally existing in three persons, the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. The Father is 100% God **in unity** with the Son and the Holy Spirit, the Son is 100% God **in unity** with the Father and the Holy Spirit, and the Holy Spirit is 100% God **in unity** with the Father and the Son. The three persons have the same essence, being, and substance. The three persons and the unity of the Godhead as **one being** is a mystery that is difficult to understand. Yet, the sacred Scripture wholly supports and substantiates the doctrine of the Holy Trinity.

TRINITY IS ONE IN ESSENCE AND THREE IN PERSON



The best way to grasp the Holy Trinity is to understand what it is not. It is not 'tri-theism' (i.e., three separate deities or trimoorties) as in Hinduism or Mormonism. It is not 'Modalism' where it is believed that God is one person who has revealed himself in three forms or modes like a single actor playing the role of three characters in different scenes in a mono-act play. The Holy Trinity is not 'Monarchianism' where it is believed that the Father is only God, who is equated to a supreme monarch. The Son and the Holy Spirit are less than God.

The Holy Church teaches and believes that the being of God (or the essence of God or substance of God) is one. The three persons within the unity of the Godhead are eternal and co-equal. Therefore, there is no ranking within the persons of the Godhead.

How can I, a sinner, be justified by God?

Now comes the importance of the good news, the gospel of Jesus Christ. Since man, in his ability, cannot get right with God due to his sinful nature God had Himself promised a Messiah (savior or deliverer or rescuer). The promised Messiah is Jesus, the Son of God. God gifted Him as a perfect substitute for the sinner to be a sin-offering. By His virgin birth, God the Son became truly human yet without sin. He took upon Himself (i.e. on the body of the likeness of sinful nature) our guilt of sin and suffered the wrath of God against it **for us and as us**. Regarding the transfer of the guilt of sin on the body of the likeness of sinful nature, the sacred scripture says, *'For God made Christ, who never sinned, to be the offering for our sin so that we could be made right with God through Christ.'* [2 Corinthians 5:21 – NLT]. Another version: *'He made Him who knew no sin to be sin on our behalf so that we might become the righteousness of God in Him.'* [2 Corinthians 5:21 – NASB].

We read: *"The law of Moses (i.e., the Ten Commandments) was unable to save us because of the weakness of our sinful nature. So, God did what the law could not do. He sent his own Son in a body like the bodies we sinners have. And in that body,*

God declared an end to sin's control over us *by giving his Son as a sacrifice for our sins*. He did this so that the just requirement of the law would be fully satisfied for us, who no longer follow our sinful nature but instead follow the Spirit." [Romans 8:3-4]. "He (Jesus) himself bore our sins in his body on the tree (i.e., the cross), that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. By his wounds, you have been healed." [1 Peter 2:24 ESV]

"Okay, I got the gospel message. Since Jesus died for all, I understand, I am automatically included, justified, and saved from the wrath of God to come. Is my understanding correct?"

No; your understanding is not correct. You are not automatically included and justified. Here comes the importance of the third keyword, 'belief'. God's offer of salvation through His Son Jesus Christ is an 'offer in general'. But to appropriate that offer you need to respond to that offer by ratifying the person of Jesus as the Son of God, sent by God the Father as your substitute to save you from your sins. You must also acknowledge that His death, burial, and resurrection were for you and on your behalf. Only then can you appropriate the salvation of God. In one sense, your FAITH (OR TRUST) acts

as a power of attorney in favor of Jesus Christ to plead your case on the Day of Judgment. Unless you ratify Jesus Christ by believing in this manner you cannot avail yourself of the benefit of God's offer. **In other words, you cannot continue to be an unbeliever and at the same time appropriate God's salvation that comes through Jesus, the Son of God. The gospel message becomes the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes.** God cannot save you unless you believe (or trust, or embrace) the Savior He gifted.

What should I believe?

Your belief should include the following essential elements:

- That Jesus born of the Virgin Mary by the power of the Holy Spirit is God the Son, the Savior (or the Rescuer or the Deliverer) sent by God the Father.
- That Jesus, as your substitute, took upon the body of the likeness of sinful nature (i.e., the human body) your 'guilt of sin'. Jesus paid the death penalty on the cross that was due to you.
- That Jesus, the guiltless man, was consumed by the wrath of God because of your guilt that was transferred to Him. That Jesus tasted

death on your behalf for your sake. We read: *'But we see him who for a little while was made lower than the angels, namely Jesus, crowned with glory and honor because of the suffering of death, so that by the grace of God he might taste death for everyone.'* [Hebrews 2:9 - ESV].

- That Jesus was buried; on the third day He was raised from the dead because of His sinlessness. And that He lives forever. [He lived on the earth as a man in full compliance with the requirements of the Ten Commandments. He was raised on the third day because of His earned righteousness in His capacity as a man.]
- That Jesus Christ was glorified in His death, burial, and resurrection. And that God the Father bestowed on Him all authority in heaven and on earth and raised Him to the highest designation (name), the LORD (i.e. God above all). Holy Scripture attests to this fact. We read, *'Therefore God has highly exalted him and bestowed on him the name that is above every name, so that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth, and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.'* (Philippians 2:9-11- ESV).

- That Jesus will come again in glory to judge the living and the dead; and that His kingdom will have no end.
- That by grace alone through your faith alone in Christ alone, the righteousness of Jesus Christ is credited to you.
- That because you trusted in the vicarious death of Jesus Christ you are reconciled with God; the enmity having been removed.

By acknowledging and ratifying Jesus as your substitute, trusting in His works of salvation on the cross, God had already satisfied His righteous requirement concerning your 'guilt of sin'. We read:

Romans 5:6 (ESV): - 'For while *we were still weak*, at the right time Christ died for the ungodly.'

Romans 5:8 (ESV): - 'But God shows his love for us in that while *we were still sinners*, Christ died for us.'

Romans 5:10 (ESV): - 'For if *while we were enemies* we were reconciled to God by the death of his Son, much more, now that we are reconciled, shall we be saved by his life.'

God will NOT punish you twice for the same guilt. When you have believed in this manner you are clothed in the righteousness of the Son

of God, Jesus Christ. The sacred Scripture testifies to this truth. We read:

Isaiah 61:10 – (ESV): - 'I will greatly rejoice in the Lord; my soul shall exult in my God, for *he has clothed me with the garments of salvation; he has covered me with the robe of righteousness, as a bridegroom decks himself like a priest with a beautiful headdress, and as a bride adorns herself with her jewels.*' [Isaiah 61:10 -ESV]

Job 29:14 – (ESV): - 'I *put on righteousness, and it clothed me; my justice was like a robe and a turban.*'

Revelation 19:6-8 – (ESV): - 'Then I heard what seemed to be the voice of a great multitude, like the roar of many waters and like the sound of mighty peals of thunder, crying out, "Hallelujah! For the Lord our God, the Almighty reigns. Let us rejoice and exult and give him the glory, for the marriage of the Lamb has come, and his Bride has made herself ready; *it was granted her to clothe herself with fine linen, bright and pure*"— *for the fine linen is the righteous deeds of the saints.*'

In this way, you are now declared righteous although your sinful nature remains, saved and sanctified. Sin (or the guilt of sin) will have no power over you.

In what manner should I express my faith for salvation?

Apostle Peter admonished the Jewish people to repent and be baptized in the name of Jesus. The same applies to all non-Jews. We read: *'Now when they heard this they were cut to the heart, and said to Peter and the rest of the apostles, "Brothers, what shall we do?" And Peter said to them, "Repent and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit" [Acts 2:37-38].* So, it is through (1) your repentance, (2) belief (as above), and (3) baptism that you express your faith.

What is repentance?

Repentance is a firm determination to return to the Living God, abandoning all forms of idolatry (including saint worship and other forms of idolatry being practiced by certain Christian denominations), rebellion, and the actual return. Repentance is also a willingness to submit to the Lordship of Jesus Christ. It is an exercise of your will, not emotion. Repentance is the sinner's first response to God. True repentance must always precede true faith, and vice versa.

Without such repentance, faith alone is a mere empty profession.

What is Christian baptism?

Christian baptism is a symbolic enactment corresponding to the faith for salvation administered in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit per Matthew 28:18-20 (see below). So, we need to realize that baptism without repentance and faith becomes a mere formula that is not efficacious. We cannot bluff the Omniscient Sovereign God with a mere formula. Christian baptism is a physical act of immersion in water, symbolically identifying with the death, burial, and resurrection of Jesus Christ. The spiritual efficacy of this physical act is that you enter into a union with Christ, participating in His death, burial, and resurrection as per Romans 6: 3-11 (see below). Baptism is administered for and on behalf of Jesus Christ, complying with His command. Hence it is called 'baptism in the name of Jesus'. By undergoing baptism in this manner, you are completing the process of faith in Christ. **With the baptism, you embark on a spiritual journey to eternal glory.** If you hold fast to your faith in Christ your salvation remains. When you lose faith (i.e., rejecting Christ by trusting other

deities/names /mediums/saints/gurus/holy man/holy woman/yourself/your deeds) you also lose salvation. However, it is most unlikely for a true believer, the twice-born, to lose his/her salvation. There is an exclusiveness in true Christian faith. Therefore, there is no compromise. Consider this acronym: F.A.I.T.H. = FORSAKING ALL I TOOK HIM (JESUS).

Matthew 28:18-20

'And Jesus came and said to them, "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age."

Romans 6: 3-11

*'Do you not know that all of us who have been baptized **into** Christ Jesus were baptized **into** his death? We were buried therefore with him by baptism **into** death, in order that, just as Christ was raised from the dead by the glory of the Father, we too might walk in newness of life. For if we have been **united with him** in a death like his, we shall certainly **be united with him** in a resurrection like his. We know that our old self was crucified with him in order that the body of sin might be brought to*

nothing so that we would no longer be enslaved to sin. For one who has died has been set free from sin. Now if we have died with Christ, we believe that we will also live with him. We know that Christ, being raised from the dead, will never die again; death no longer has dominion over him. For the death he died he died to sin, once and for all, but the life he lives he lives to God. So you also must consider yourselves dead to sin and alive to God in Christ Jesus.'

Are you saved? Or do you have the assurance of salvation?

The watershed between the saved and unsaved status is in the effect salvation produces in the person, namely the conversion experience – the transformation. Such a person will also have the assurance of salvation. Our Lord Jesus Christ while explaining the process of being born again to Nicodemus, compared it to the wind. Jesus said, *“The wind blows where it wishes, and you hear its sound, but you do not know where it comes from or where it goes. So, it is with everyone who is born of the Spirit.”* (John 3:8). Although the wind cannot be seen its effects are amply manifested. So is the case with the born-again person. He/she should have some kind of conversion or transformation experience. If you do not have the assurance of salvation or conversion

experience, in all probability, your status is that you are unsaved. If that is the case, then I urge you to get saved now. Now is the time to get saved, so says the Bible. We read: *“As God’s partners, we beg you not to accept this marvelous gift of God’s kindness and then ignore it. For God says, “At just the right time, I heard you. On the day of salvation, I helped you.” Indeed, the “right time” is now. Today is the day of salvation”*
[2 Corinthians 6:1-2 NLT]

I want to respond to God concerning His gospel message. Can you give me a model prayer to pray?

Certainly, it’s my pleasure. A model prayer of repentance is given below. First, you read it, and if you are agreeable to it, word by word, you may say the prayer with utmost sincerity and seriousness. Please note that sin emerges from a wicked heart as lust, evil desires and thoughts, words, and deeds. The Bible says that the human heart (i.e., the inner being) is deceitful above all things and desperately wicked. We read: *‘The heart is **deceitful** above all things and desperately **wicked**; Who can know it? I, the Lord, search the heart, I test the mind, even to give every man according to his ways, according to the fruit of his*

doings.' (Jeremiah 17: 9-10 - NKJV). We must be aware of our sinful nature and confess the same before God with a contrite heart. That is what King David did when he was convicted of his heinous crimes by the Spirit of God through the prophet Nathan. Psalms 51 is his prayer of repentance with contrition. The prayer below is Psalms 51 but paraphrased and adapted to include the sin offering of Jesus Christ made by His death on the cross, burial, and resurrection. If you offer this prayer with contrition and without hypocrisy, I am sure, it will be efficacious in the spiritual realm.

A Prayer of Repentance with A Contrite Heart

“Have mercy on me, O God, according to Your steadfast love; according to Your abundant mercy blot out my transgressions. Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity and cleanse me from my sin! For I know my transgressions and my sin is ever before me. Against You, You only, have I sinned and done what is evil in Your sight, so that You may be justified in Your words and blameless in Your judgment. Behold, I was brought forth in iniquity, and in sin did my mother conceive me.

Create in me a clean heart, O God, and renew a right spirit within me. Do not banish me from Your presence. O God of my salvation, then I will joyfully sing of Your forgiveness. Help me to experience the joy of Your salvation and make me willing to obey You. O Lord, open my lips, and my mouth will declare Your praise. The sacrifice You desire is a broken spirit. You will not reject a broken and repentant heart, O God.

You said in Your sacred Scriptures: *'If you declare with your mouth, "Jesus is Lord," and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved.'* (Romans 10:9). Right now, I confess Jesus Christ as my Lord and my personal Saviour. With my heart, I believe that You raised Him from the dead on the third day.

Abba! Father, credit it for me Jesus' propitiation by offering Himself on the cross bearing the guilt of my sin on His body of sinful likeness and shedding His innocent blood. Hide Your face from my sins and blot out all my iniquities. Deliver me from the guilt of my sin, O God. Purge me with the shed blood of Your Son, Jesus Christ, and I

shall be clean; wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow.

According to the greatness of Your name, Your unfailing faithfulness, and according to Your promise, I believe that You heard my plea and that You have forgiven my sins. And I thank You for forgiving my sins and rescuing me from eternal death.” Amen.

THE MORAL LAWS OF GOD

THE TEN COMMANDMENTS

(Abbreviated from Exodus 20: 2-16 &
Deuteronomy 5: 6-21)

OWINGS (OR INDEBTEDNESS) TOWARDS GOD:

- 1 'YAHWEH' ('I AM') is the Lord your God; You shall have no other gods before me.
- 2 You shall not make for yourself a carved image —any likeness of anything that is in heaven above, or that is in the earth beneath, or that is in the water under the earth; you shall not bow down to them nor serve (worship) them.
- 3 You shall not take the name of the Lord your God in vain, for the Lord will not hold him guiltless who takes His name in vain.
- 4 Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy.

OWINGS (OR INDEBTEDNESS) TOWARDS FELLOW BEINGS:

- 5 Honor your father and your mother, that your days may be long upon the land which the Lord your God is giving you.
- 6 You shall not murder.

7 You shall not commit adultery.

8 You shall not steal.

9 You shall not bear false witness against your neighbor.' (Or, You shall not deceive your neighbor)

OWINGS (OR INDEBTEDNESS) TOWARDS GOD AND FELLOW BEINGS:

10 You shall not covet (i.e. You shall not even desire to break any of the nine other Commandments).

SOLA SCRIPTURA ("by Scripture alone"): - The phrase, 'sola scriptura', or 'by scripture alone', asserts that the Bible must determine church traditions and interpretations. All church practices and doctrines must be in unity with the teachings of Scripture, the divinely inspired Word of God. This principle asserts that the Bible is to be interpreted through itself, with one passage of Scripture being useful in the interpretation of other passages. It shows that the Bible is a unified system of truth as well as the revelation of truth. The teachings and customs of the church must align themselves with the Word of God; only then can they be applied with any assurance of God's approval and their own trustworthiness.

THE GREAT RESCUE

The Answers to Pertinent Questions

ALEX M KURUVILLA